Daniel Chapter 11: A Prophetic Overview (533 B.C. - 164 B.C.)

Daniel receives this prophecy in the third year of Cyrus (Cyrus the Great, ~536 B.C.), delivered by an angel who "strengthened Darius the Mede" (~539 B.C.) in his first year (v. 1).

- God, throughout the Old Testament, provides a running timeline of history, from Adam and Eve, their offspring, Noah, the world after the flood, Abraham through the birth of the 12 sons of Israel, Moses and the Egyptian dynasty, the Exodus, the nations of Canaan, the entering into the promised land by the Israelites, their errors in the time of Judges, their demand of a King, the history of the Kingdom, its split, the destruction of the northern Kingdom of Israel by the Assyrian Empire, their destruction at the hands of the rising Babylonian empire, the captivity of the Jews of the Southern Kingdom of Judea, and earlier in Daniel, the prophecy of King Nebuchadnezzar's dream detailing his empire and future empires, the fall of Babylonian control, and rise of the Medes and Persians. Daniel would also tell of the eventual return of the Jews to Jerusalem (along with other major and minor prophets).
- We know from the New Testament the rule of the Roman Empire over Judea in Jesus' and the Apostles' time. However, there is a gap of history of roughly 450 years between the 2nd temple era that began following the return out of exile, and the time of Christ.
- Daniel chapter 11 bridges this gap with stunning prophecy that outlines historical events from the Persian Empire through the Greek kingdoms, focusing on conflicts between the King of the North (Seleucid Empire) and the King of the South (Ptolemaic Empire), leading to Antiochus Epiphanes' actions, foreshadowing end-times events. Written by Daniel in the 6th century B.C. (~533 B.C.), this prophecy spans nearly four centuries of secular history with an accuracy that would be humanly impossible. It meticulously details the intricate political marriages, military betrayals, and rise and fall of empires playing out all the way down to 164 B.C. proving that only an omniscient God could dictate such precise historical realities hundreds of years before they occurred.

Verse-by-Verse Summary

- ***Daniel 11:1*** *Also I in the first year of Darius the Mede, even I, stood to confirm and to strengthen him.*
  - The angel recalls supporting Darius the Mede (~539 B.C.) during his reign's start.
- ***Daniel 11:2*** *And now will I shew thee the truth. Behold, there shall stand up yet three kings in Persia; and the fourth shall be far richer than they all: and by his strength through his riches he shall stir up all against the realm of Grecia.*
  - After Cyrus (Cyrus the Great, ~559–530 B.C.), three kings arise: Cambyses II (~530–522 B.C.), Darius I (~522–486 B.C.), and Ahasuerus (Xerxes I, ~486–465 B.C.), the richest, who attacks Greece, leading to battles like Thermopylae (~480 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:3–4*** *And a mighty king shall stand up, that shall rule with great dominion, and do according to his will. And when he shall stand up, his kingdom shall be broken, and shall be divided toward the four winds of heaven; and not to his posterity, nor according*

to his dominion which he ruled: for his kingdom shall be plucked up, even for others beside those.

- Alexander the Great (~336–323 B.C.) conquers widely but dies young, his empire splitting among four generals: Ptolemy (Egypt), Seleucus (Mesopotamia), Lysimachus (Asia Minor), and Cassander (Greece) (~323 B.C.).

- ***Daniel 11:5*** *And the king of the south shall be strong, and one of his princes; and he shall be strong above him, and have dominion; his dominion shall be a great dominion.*
  - Ptolemy I Soter (~323–283 B.C.), King of the South (Egypt), grows strong, but Seleucus I Nicator (~311–281 B.C.), King of the North (Mesopotamia), becomes stronger.
- ***Daniel 11:6*** *And in the end of years they shall join themselves together; for the king's daughter of the south shall come to the king of the north to make an agreement: but she shall not retain the power of the arm; neither shall he stand, nor his arm: but she shall be given up, and they that brought her, and he that begat her, and he that strengthened her in these times.*
  - Berenice, daughter of Ptolemy II Philadelphus (~283–246 B.C.), marries Antiochus II Theos (~261–246 B.C.) to form an alliance (~252 B.C.), but the deal fails after Ptolemy's death, and Berenice is abandoned.
- ***Daniel 11:7–8*** *But out of a branch of her roots shall one stand up in his estate, which shall come with an army, and shall enter into the fortress of the king of the north, and shall deal against them, and shall prevail: And shall also carry captives into Egypt their gods, with their princes, and with their precious vessels of silver and of gold; and he shall continue more years than the king of the north.*
  - Ptolemy III Euergetes (~246–222 B.C.), a relative of Berenice, invades the North, defeats Seleucus II Callinicus (~246–225 B.C.), and returns to Egypt with captives and treasures (~241 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:9–10*** *So the king of the south shall come into his kingdom, and shall return into his own land. But his sons shall be stirred up, and shall assemble a multitude of great forces: and one shall certainly come, and overflow, and pass through: then shall he return, and be stirred up, even to his fortress.*
  - Ptolemy III returns home, but Seleucus II's sons, Seleucus III Ceraunus (~225–223 B.C.) and Antiochus III the Great (~223–187 B.C.), assemble forces to retaliate.
- ***Daniel 11:11–12*** *And the king of the south shall be moved with choler, and shall come forth and fight with him, even with the king of the north: and he shall set forth a great multitude; but the multitude shall be given into his hand. And when he hath taken away the multitude, his heart shall be lifted up; and he shall cast down many ten thousands: but he shall not be strengthened by it.*
  - Ptolemy IV Philopator (~221–204 B.C.) defeats Antiochus III (~219 B.C.), but his prideful victory doesn't strengthen him.
- ***Daniel 11:13–15*** *For the king of the north shall return, and shall set forth a multitude greater than the former, and shall certainly come after certain years with a great army and with much riches. And in those times there shall many stand up against the king of the south: also the robbers of thy people shall exalt themselves to establish the vision; but they shall fall. So the king of the north shall come, and cast up a mount, and take the*

most fenced cities: and the arms of the south shall not withstand, neither his chosen people, neither shall there be any strength to withstand.

- Antochus III returns with a larger army, allies with others against Ptolemy V Epiphanes (~204–180 B.C.), and captures fortified cities (~200 B.C.).
- **v. 14 Detail:** Jewish opportunists try to exploit the conflict for gain but fail (~200 B.C.).

- ***Daniel 11:16*** *But he that cometh against him shall do according to his own will, and none shall stand before him: and he shall stand in the glorious land, which by his hand shall be consumed.*
  - Antiochus III defeats Ptolemy V and occupies Israel, harming it (~198 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:17*** *He shall also set his face to enter with the strength of his whole kingdom, and upright ones with him; thus shall he do: and he shall give him the daughter of women, corrupting her: but she shall not stand on his side, neither be for him.*

  - Antiochus III sends his daughter, Cleopatra I (~193–176 B.C.), to marry Ptolemy V (~192 B.C.), but she sides with Egypt, thwarting his plan.
- ***Daniel 11:18–19*** *After this shall he turn his face unto the isles, and shall take many: but a prince for his own behalf shall cause the reproach offered by him to cease; without his own reproach he shall cause it to turn upon him. Then he shall turn his face toward the fort of his own land: but he shall stumble and fall, and not be found.*

  - Antiochus III wins naval battles but is defeated by a Roman prince (Scipio Asiaticus, ~190 B.C.), returns home, and dies (~187 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:20*** *Then shall stand up in his estate a raiser of taxes in the glory of the kingdom: but within few days he shall be destroyed, neither in anger, nor in battle.*
  - Seleucus IV Philopator (~187–175 B.C.) focuses on taxation but dies mysteriously, not in battle (~175 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:21–22*** *And in his estate shall stand up a vile person, to whom they shall not give the honour of the kingdom: but he shall come in peaceably, and obtain the kingdom by flatteries. And with the arms of a flood shall they be overflown from before him, and shall be broken; yea, also the prince of the covenant.*
  - Antiochus IV Epiphanes (~175–164 B.C.), a vile person, seizes power through flattery, defeats opponents, and kills the high priest (Onias III, ~171 B.C.), the “prince of the covenant.”
- ***Daniel 11:23–24*** *And after the league made with him he shall work deceitfully: for he shall come up, and shall become strong with a small people. He shall enter peaceably even upon the fattest places of the province; and he shall do that which his fathers have not done, nor his fathers' fathers; he shall scatter among them the prey, and spoil, and riches: yea, and he shall forecast his devices against the strong holds, even for a time.*
  - Antiochus IV makes deceptive alliances, gains strength, and uses occult practices to conquer strongholds (~170 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:25–26*** *And he shall stir up his power and his courage against the king of the south with a great army; and the king of the south shall be stirred up to battle with a very*

great and mighty army; but he shall not stand: for they shall forecast devices against him. Yea, they that feed of the portion of his meat shall destroy him, and his army shall overflow: and many shall fall down slain.

- Antiochus IV defeats Ptolemy VI Philometor (~170–164 B.C.) in battle, aided by betrayal within Egypt (~169 B.C.).

- ***Daniel 11:27*** *And both these kings' hearts shall be to do mischief, and they shall speak lies at one table; but it shall not prosper: for yet the end shall be at the time appointed.*
  - Antiochus IV and Ptolemy VI negotiate deceitfully, but their plans fail (~169 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:28*** *Then shall he return into his land with great riches; and his heart shall be against the holy covenant; and he shall do exploits, and return to his own land.*
  - Antiochus IV returns home, plotting against Israel's religion (~168 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:29–30*** *At the time appointed he shall return, and come toward the south; but it shall not be as the former, or as the latter. For the ships of Chittim shall come against him: therefore he shall be grieved, and return, and have indignation against the holy covenant: so shall he do; he shall even return, and have intelligence with them that forsake the holy covenant.*
  - Antiochus IV's second campaign against Egypt is halted by Roman ships (Popilius Laenas, ~168 B.C.), and he turns his anger on Israel, allying with apostate Jews.
- ***Daniel 11:31*** *And arms shall stand on his part, and they shall pollute the sanctuary of strength, and shall take away the daily sacrifice, and they shall place the abomination that maketh desolate.*
  - Antiochus IV and apostate Jews desecrate the temple, stop sacrifices, and set up a statue of Zeus, the "abomination that maketh desolate" (~168 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:32*** *And such as do wickedly against the covenant shall he corrupt by flatteries: but the people that do know their God shall be strong, and do exploits.*
  - Antiochus IV empowers apostate Jews, but faithful Jews resist and perform exploits (~168 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:33–35*** *And they that understand among the people shall instruct many: yet they shall fall by the sword, and by flame, by captivity, and by spoil, many days. Now when they shall fall, they shall be holpen with a little help: but many shall cleave to them with flatteries. And some of them of understanding shall fall, to try them, and to purge, and to make them white, even to the time of the end: because it is yet for a time appointed.*
  - Faithful Jews teach others but face persecution, martyrdom, and trials, receiving some help (~168–164 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:36–37*** *And the king shall do according to his will; and he shall exalt himself, and magnify himself above every god, and shall speak marvellous things against the God of gods, and shall prosper till the indignation be accomplished: for that that is determined shall be done. Neither shall he regard the God of his fathers, nor the desire of women, nor regard any god: for he shall magnify himself above all.*
  - Antiochus IV exalts himself above all gods, possibly as a sodomite, rejecting traditional deities (~168 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:38–39*** *But in his estate shall he honour the God of forces: and a god whom his fathers knew not shall he honour with gold, and silver, and with precious stones, and*

pleasant things. Thus shall he do in the most strong holds with a strange god, whom he shall acknowledge and increase with glory: and he shall cause them to rule over many, and shall divide the land for gain.

- Antiochus IV worships an impersonal "god of forces," promoting it with riches and dividing land for gain (~168 B.C.).

- ***Daniel 11:40–43*** *And at the time of the end shall the king of the south push at him: and the king of the north shall come against him like a whirlwind, with chariots, and with horsemen, and with many ships; and he shall enter into the countries, and shall overflow and pass over. He shall enter also into the glorious land, and many countries shall be overthrown: but these shall escape out of his hand, even Edom, and Moab, and the chief of the children of Ammon. He shall stretch forth his hand also upon the countries: and the land of Egypt shall not escape. But he shall have power over the treasures of gold and of silver, and over all the precious things of Egypt: and the Libyans and the Ethiopians shall be at his steps.*
  - Antiochus IV defeats Ptolemy VI again, conquers Egypt, Libya, and Ethiopia, but spares Edom, Moab, and Ammon (~167 B.C.).
- ***Daniel 11:44–45*** *But tidings out of the east and out of the north shall trouble him: therefore he shall go forth with great fury to destroy, and utterly to make away many. And he shall plant the tabernacles of his palace between the seas in the glorious holy mountain; yet he shall come to his end, and none shall help him.*
  - Antiochus IV, disturbed by eastern and northern news, sets up his palace in Israel between the seas, but dies without human hand (~164 B.C.).

Conclusion

- Daniel 11 meticulously details historical events from the Persian kings to Antiochus Epiphanes' desecration of the temple, fulfilled between 533 B.C. and 164 B.C.
- While historically accurate, it also serves to foreshadow end-times events involving a future Antichrist, abomination of desolation, and persecution of God's people, as elaborated in Daniel 12.
- This chapter underscores the precision of biblical prophecy and its dual application to history and the future, giving us faith in God's word, and an undeniable proof of its truth.

-Chris Coon, 10/3/2025